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Volunteer Brand Equity? Exploring the Adoption of Employee Brand Equity (EBE) Dimensions to Understand Volunteers' Contributions to Build Nonprofit Organizations' Brands

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ABSTRACT

Given the importance of volunteers as key assets of formal volunteering organizations, this paper explores the adoption and adequacy of Employee Brand Equity (EBE) models to understand volunteers' contributions to Nonprofit Organization (NPO) brand equity. Methodologically this research embraces a mixed-methods approach by combining data from exploratory interviews with experts from the NPO context and from a survey to 227 Portuguese volunteers from 28 formal volunteering organizations. This paper adds to the literature by applying for the first time EBE dimensions to the context of formal volunteering institutions. Hence, it provides a first step to the development of a Volunteer Brand Equity Model, by characterizing each dimension and validating its importance in the context of NPOs. From a practitioners' viewpoint, this paper calls attention to the importance of embracing internal marketing strategies to attract and retain volunteers in a sustainable way and provides a practical tool for Volunteer Brand Equity analysis in NPOs.

KEYWORDS

NPOs characteristics; formal volunteering organizations; employee based brand equity; brand management in NPOs; volunteer brand equity

Introduction

Nonprofit organizations (NPO) face serious challenges in attracting and retaining volunteers and in obtaining funding opportunities to reach their goals (Andreasen & Kotler, 2003; Bussell & Forbes, 2002; Drollinger, 2018; Harp, Scherer, & Allen, 2017; Pope, Isely, & Asamoah-Tutu, 2009). The literature on the topic calls attention to the importance of brand management as one of NPO's most important assets to face those challenges (Chapleo, 2015; Ewing & Napoli, 2005; Garg, Swami, & Malhotra, 2019; Hankinson, 2001; Huang & Ku, 2016), revealing that a growing number of NPOs is already adopting marketing strategies to differentiate them from competing NPOs (Pope et al., 2009; Sargeant, Ford, & Hudson, 2008; Voeth & Herbst, 2008; Weerawardena, 2018).

In general, researchers in the area provide contributions on the importance of communicating NPO brands to the public (Bruce, Byrne, & Myers, 2018; Hankinson, 2004), and some evidence on how internal marketing strategies may reinforce brand awareness (Hume & Hume, 2015; Liu, Chapleo, Ko, & Ngugi, 2015), ignoring however the role of volunteers in building up NPOs brand equity and conveying brand promises. According to Bussell and Forbes (2002, p. 14) volunteers “are the most important group of customers for a voluntary organization”.

So far, the literature does not provide theoretical or empirical insights on the adequacy of adopting employee brand equity dimensions (e.g. King & Grace, 2005, 2009, 2010; King, Grace, & Funk, 2012) to explain the contribution of volunteers to NPOs’ brand equity. As such, this paper intends to bridge this gap by presenting the results of an exploratory pilot study where the dimensions of Employee Brand Equity (EBE) models (King & Grace, 2009, 2010) were applied to the context of formal voluntary work in NPOs. In this sense, we seek to understand volunteers’ contributions to build up NPOs’ brand equity and to advance with a proposal for a Volunteer Brand Equity (VBE) model. Therefore, this article contributes to the currently limited literature on the importance of internal marketing strategies to attract and retain volunteers and, more importantly to the under-researched area of building brand equity from volunteers’ relationships with their NPO brands. The remainder of our study is structured as follows. The next section introduces our theoretical framework and research questions, followed by our methodological decisions toward a mixed approach, data analysis and discussion, and finally conclusions and implications of the study.

Theoretical framework

This section presents our theoretical framework in four sections: (a) introduces volunteering work in NPOs, (b) aligns main contributions on brand management in NPOs, (c) describes main features and dimensions of EBE models and (d) advances a research model of volunteering brand equity, based on EBE dimensions.

Volunteering in NPOs

Volunteering work can be classified as either formal (organization-based) or informal (outside of formal organizations) (Adams and Deane, 2009; Lee & Brudney, 2012), leading to different types of goals, operations, levels of engagement, and particularly different impacts on individuals (Dovidio et al., 2017).

Previous studies have found differences in expectations and levels of satisfaction of volunteers when compared to paid workers, as the type of work and organizations are substantially different (Vantilborgh et al., 2012;

Boezeman and Ellemers 2009). Volunteer work tends to be characterized by a relative sense of autonomy, independence, egalitarianism (Boezeman & Ellemers, 2009; Vantilborgh et al., 2012; Nichols 2013). However, there is also evidence of similarities between both. Liao-Troth (2001) concluded that “volunteers and paid employees in the same location, performing similar work, and subject to similar work rules, procedures, contracts, expectations, discipline, and evaluations have job attitudes similar to one another for psychological contracts (except regarding benefits), affective commitment, and organizational justice.” (p.435).

Motivations and satisfaction are two dimensions often discussed in the literature on Volunteering work, which in turn, are also widely discussed in the EBBE literature. Unquestionably, volunteers present different motivations and satisfaction levels than employees. However, parallelisms can be made between both approaches. Motivations are mainly linked to altruism. Individuals become volunteers and devote themselves to NPOs simply because they desire to feel useful and occupy free time helping and benefiting third parties (Anderson & Moore, 1978; McSweeney & Alexander, 1996; Bussell & Forbes, 2002; Okun, 1994; Gidron, 1983) without being subject to economic or social constraints (Galindo-Kuhn & Guzley, 2002). Motivations also emerge from a tendency to attribute value to intangible rewards (Gidron, 1985) such as social contact, recognition of shared moral values among peers (Riecken, Babakus, & Yavas, 1994), confidence development whether to perform in professional levels (Gora & Nemerowicz, 1991) or to gain credits in university contexts (Johnson-Coffey, 1997), networking and job opportunities (Rifkin, 1995), traveling to foreign countries (Wilson & Pimm, 1996), opportunity to express and share religious beliefs (Mattis et al., 2000), friendship relationships that are created while volunteering (Pearce, 1983; Vinokur-Kaplan, Jayaratne, & Chess, 1994) or that motivate volunteering in the first place (Nichols & King, 1998). This can be related to the process of organizational socialization put forward by King and Grace (2010), in the EBBE model, according to which employees’ motivation arise from the set of socialization processes between peers within the organization, promoting a system of shared values, beliefs and objectives (Kelley, 1992).

Regarding volunteers’ satisfaction, the literature emphasizes the importance of quality communication within the NPO (Bennett & Barkensjo, 2005; Field & Johnson, 1993; Miller, Powell, & Seltzer, 1990). Factors such as flow and clarity of information, feedback, and recognition were considered to be very relevant to volunteers’ satisfaction. Task distribution is also suggested as an active influencer of volunteers’ satisfaction (Miller et al., 1990), particularly regarding the match between requirements of the task and volunteer’s ability and convenience to perform it (Stevens, 1991). EBBE also provides rich insights on the importance of role clarity as a satisfaction promoter of employees (King & Grace, 2010) which will be discussed in more detail below. Satisfaction is also dependent on the

effectiveness of volunteers' participation, that is, the positive impact of volunteers' actions on their target audience (Miller et al., 1990; Omoto & Snyder, 1995). The absence of this dimension is recognized as one major driver for unsatisfied volunteers and abandonment rates (Morrow-Howell & Mui, 1989). Satisfaction is also discussed in the literature as dependent on group integration and social interactions (Black & DiNitto, 1995), and on encouragement, emotional and pedagogical support during training stages (Cyr & Dowrick, 1991).

Brand management in NPOs

Brand management in NPOs is a relatively recent phenomena. Wray (1994) started by questioning why one of the most valuable assets of organizations, the brand, was so poorly used by the charitable sector. Tapp (1996) reflected on the emergent need for NPOs to differentiate from others while Hankinson (2000) mentioned the importance of using branding to build confidence and actively work on fundraising. Ali (2001), in turn, emphasized the brand's ability to communicate the mission and purpose of charities.

Nowadays one cannot ignore the power of brands in communicating NPOs' missions and values and in obtaining resources (Liu et al., 2015). For example, World Wildlife Fund, Red Cross, International Amnesty, are widely recognized and valued brands. Research shows that strong NPO brands have an important role in retaining volunteers (Laidler-Kylander, Austin, & Quelch, 2004), in the same way that successful corporate brands might attract attention of more job seekers (Wei, Chang, Lin, & Liang, 2016; Gatewood, Gowan, & Lautenschlager, 1993).

Despite the rising debate on the topic, the literature is mainly focused on NPO brands as visibility enablers in the context of external communication, thus providing favorable positions in relation to competing institutions and recognition among target audiences. There are also debates around the holistic function of NPO brands in the creation of greater social impact, which assumes brand management as strategically relevant for the organization's own development in line with its mission, values, and identity. Concepts and strategies of brand management are being adapted directly from the business context, which is justified by the usefulness of marketing strategies in NPOs' success, allowing them to communicate more clearly and efficiently with partners and sponsors of the business world. In the social economy sector, brands play an important role in achieving social impact objectives in the long term (Kylander & Stone, 2012).

Employee-based brand equity

The literature on brand equity is massive but largely inconclusive, mainly due to the complexity of its conceptualization (Christodoulides & de Chernatony, 2010). A review of the literature identifies a plethora of views on brand

equity, but no universally accepted definition (Aaker, 1991; Keller, 1998; Kim, Kim, & An, 2003). According to Aaker (1991), brand equity is “a set of assets and liabilities linked to a brand, its name, and symbol, that add to or subtract from the value provided by a product or service to a firm and/or that firm’s customers” (p.15). Value is thus discussed, on one hand from a financial view where measurement of brand equity is mainly articulated in monetary terms (e. g. Atilgan et al., 2005, Kim et al., 2003) and one a second hand from a customer-based view (e. g. Aaker, 1991; de Chernatony, Cottam, & Segal-Horn, 2006; Pappu et al., 2005; Vazquez et al., 2002; You & Donthu, 2001) where, for example, is defined as “the differential effect that brand knowledge has on consumer response to the marketing of that brand” (Keller, 1998, p. 45). In spite of its prolific adoption among researchers, the concept and measurement of brand equity is still limited, subject of further inquiries and refinements (Christodoulides & de Chernatony, 2010). For example, both Yoo and Donthu (2001) and Wasburn and Plank (2002) call for further scale development toward a universally accepted measure of consumer-based brand equity. Christodoulides and de Chernatony (2010) question the merge of two theoretically distinct constructs of brand equity – brand awareness and brand associations – into one single dimension by Yoo and Donthu’s (2001). The authors reinforce that although both Aaker (1991) and Keller (1998) found a strong correlation between the constructs, these should be considered as different. Another limitation is put forward by King and Grace (2009, 2010) who highlighted that brand equity literature is still strongly dominated by two external perspectives, as discussed above, and that the benefits that are derived from internal brand management to brand equity should also be considered, as in the EBBE model. Brand management literature strongly advocates that employees’ competences and knowledge promote a competitive advantage for organizations (de Chernatony et al., 2006) and that for organizations to perform effectively it is critical for employees to demonstrate positive organizational behaviors (King & Grace, 2009, 2010; Parker, 2007). Thus, there is a growing recognition of employees as brand ambassadors given their key role in the building process of firms’ brand equity (de Chernatony et al., 2006; King & Grace, 2010; King et al., 2012; Tavassoli, Sorescu, & Chandy, 2014). This internal dimension of brand equity is referred to as Employee-Based Brand Equity (EBBE), later translated simply as Employee Brand Equity (EBE) and can be defined as “the differential effect that brand knowledge has on employee’s response to internal brand management” (King et al., 2012, p. 269).

Prior literature has consistently investigated brand equity from the employees’ point of view (King & Grace, 2005, 2009, 2010; King et al., 2012). EBE models provide key insights on how knowledge hold by employees about the brand’s promises, values, and mission, may foster positive and

productive behavior of employees coherent with the communicated brand identity (Brexendort & Kernstock, 2007). King and Grace (2009, 2010) propose EBBE models divided into three main categories – Internal Brand Management, Effects of Brand Knowledge and EBBE Benefits – which are broken down into 13 dimensions, briefly reviewed below.

“Internal Brand Management” emerges as a dimension of information management, conveying brand knowledge, in the sense of empowering employees in the process of “delivering” the brand promise. This knowledge transfer has a positive effect on employees, namely on brand commitment and awareness of the importance of their roles and functions (King & Grace, 2005). Seven dimensions compose the first category of the model. The dimension “Information generation” (1) addresses the need to understand how the brand is perceived by employees, and occurs when employees interpret a particular aspect of the organization and share their personal opinion about it (King & Grace, 2009; Lings, 2004). This feedback exercise allows a collection of information essential for the internal communication process and is vital for the good functioning of the organization (Naude, Desai, & Murphy, 2003). “Knowledge dissemination” (2) derives from the information generated previously and is concerned with the match between the knowledge about the brand that is transferred to employees and the way they communicate the brand promise to the external environment (King & Grace, 2009; Lings & Greenly, 2005). According to the authors, this relationship between external transmission of brand identity and the ability to generate an image consistent with that identity allows employees to present positive behaviors toward the brand. Thus, the development of an organizational climate where it is possible to share information about the brand (often called as “openness” in the literature) is very important for the improvement of internal brand management practices (King & Grace, 2010; Naude et al., 2003). Related to empowering active participation, “Employee involvement” (3) plays an important role in reinforcing organizational commitment (King & Grace, 2010), and is manifested in feedback initiatives, discussion of organizational issues, or participation in decision-making situations (Conduit & Mavondo, 2001). The dimension “Employee attitude toward work” (4), which is indirectly influenced by the previous dimensions, is the employee’s response and feelings to the way he or she is treated in the organization. This dimension has a considerable impact on the organization-employee communication process as it conditions their overall satisfaction (Naude et al., 2003). “Organizational socialization” (5) refers to the set of processes that promote employees’ evaluation of values, beliefs, and goals of the employer organization (King & Grace, 2010). Associated with the development of expectations (Naude et al., 2003), this dimension normally entails increases in employees’ motivation, working efforts and organizational commitment (Kelley, 1992). In order to create an open organizational

environment that promotes the development of close relationships with employees, “Management support” (6) is an important factor for successful employee performance (Bell, Menguc, & Stefani, 2004; Naude et al., 2003) and manifests itself through the way the organization supports and values their employees’ work. Lastly “The H factor” (7) deals with the ability to foster positive relationships, hence improving the results of internal brand management practices (King & Grace, 2010).

Regarding the second category – “Effects of Brand Knowledge” – there are two main effects that result from the correct dissemination of brand knowledge to employees: a clarification of their role in the organization and higher levels of brand commitment (King & Grace, 2009). “Role clarity” (8) dimension can be defined as the level of employees’ understanding and knowledge about his/her role in the organization as a result of the internal communication process (King & Grace, 2010). Role clarity creates opportunities to develop happier, more satisfied and committed employees (Babin & Boles, 1996; Jones, Busch, & Dacin, 2003). Additionally, it is also important to ensure that employees express a genuine willingness and motivation to disseminate this knowledge and brand promise to the external environment. The dimension “Brand Commitment” (9), represented by the affective bond or sense of belonging that the employee develops in relation to the brand (King & Grace, 2010), appears as the second effect of the brand knowledge proposed by EBBE authors. This dimension is considered to be a determining factor in the development of organizational success (Morgan & Hunt, 1994), since employee’s sense of belonging influences his or her predisposition to invest further in their contribution to achieve their organization’s objectives and goals (Castro, Armario, & Del Rio, 2005; Jones et al., 2003).

Lastly, the third category of the model – “benefits of EBBE” is discussed as the set of employees’ attitudes and behaviors that promote their continuity in the organization (Bloemer & Odekerken-Schroder, 2006; King & Grace, 2010), thus enhancing employees’ satisfaction and performance (Loveman, 1998). According to King and Grace (2009, 2010), the benefits of EBBE comprise four dimensions: brand citizenship behavior, employee satisfaction, employee intention to stay and positive employee word of mouth. The manifestation of “Brand citizenship behavior” (10) emerges from employees’ consistent, spontaneous and genuine behavior with the brand promise, not imposed by the organization (Burmann & Zeplin, 2005). The second benefit is related to “Employee satisfaction” (11), characterized by the level of satisfaction of the employee in relation to his work, according to what the organization intends and appreciates (King & Grace, 2010). Moreover, this dimension is associated with other benefits such as employee retention (Boselie & van der Wiele, 2002) or positive word-of-mouth (Shinnar, Young, & Meana, 2004). The “Employee’s intention to stay” (12) is defined as the future willingness of the employee to work in the organization in the

long term (Good, Page, & Young, 1996). The last dimension addresses the “Positive employee word-of-mouth” (13) which reflects the intention and genuine interest of the employee, not only in talking positively about his/her employer but also to recommended it to others. It also illustrates a positive relationship between the degree of commitment of the employee and his/her intention to stay in the organization (Bloemer & Odekerken-Schroder, 2006).

Research model

Considering the theme under study and the conceptual framework described above, this section proposes a research framework to advance potential dimensions of a future Volunteer Brand Equity (VBE) model (Figure 1).

As mentioned above, despite the differences between paid workers and volunteers, there are also common factors in terms of psychological contracts, affective commitment and organizational justice (Liao-Troth 2001). Knowledge hold by volunteers about brands’ promises, values, and missions, may foster positive and productive behavior of volunteers coherent with the communicated brand identity. Thus, with appropriate adaptations, it will make sense to consider volunteers as important brand ambassadors. In this sense, we seek to understand volunteers “contributions to build up NPOs” brand equity based on the three building blocks proposed by EBE researchers: Internal Brand Management (Dimensions 1–7), Effects of Brand Knowledge (Dimensions 8–9) and EBE Benefits (10–13). The model depicted in Figure 1 represents the adoption of the original dimensions developed for business contexts to an NPO context. Further explanations on how the model was adapted will be provided in the methodology section.

The first step to advance toward a new VBE model constitutes our primary research question (RQ1): is it valid and adequate to apply EBE dimensions to formal volunteering contexts? Firstly, this question implies a (statistical) validation of the scales proposed by the original EBBE models applied in the context of the NPOs of Formal Volunteering. Secondly, it demands a characterization of each of the dimensions of the model in light of the volunteers’ perspectives.

Our second research question (RQ2) emerged from the literature review. Given the importance attributed to volunteers’ knowledge to perform their tasks in a positive way and in coherence with the institution mission and values, the second research question clearly asks about the relationship between the dimensions of “brand knowledge effects” and all other dimensions. Hence, it questions the relationship between “role clarity” and “brand commitment” and each of the seven dimensions of “internal brand management” and each of the four dimensions of “VBE benefits”.

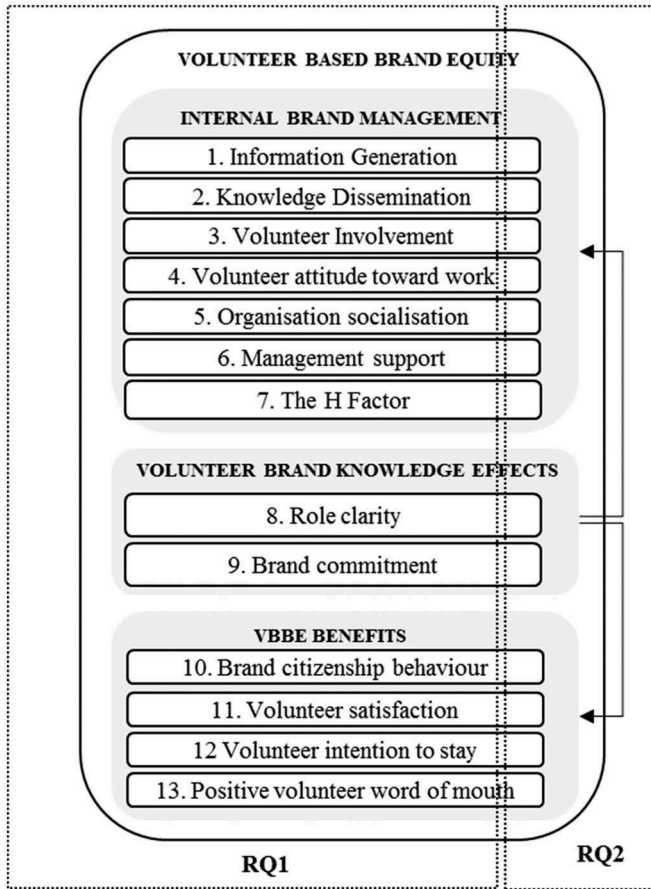


Figure 1. Research framework for a future VBE model.

Methods and data

This study adopted a mixed methods approach, combining qualitative and quantitative data collection techniques to allow for a more comprehensive investigation of the research problem (Creswell, Shope, Plano Clark, & Green, 2006). It included a self-administered questionnaire to volunteers in formal volunteering organizations (227 valid responses from 28 different NPOs) and three interviews with experts from the NPO context. The interviews served as a first step to discuss and validate our research model whereas the survey provided a greater scope of analysis. The triangulation of qualitative and quantitative data offered a greater confidence in the conclusions (Bryman, 2006).

Qualitative research design: participants, data collection and analysis

Given the exploratory nature of the study and the scarcity of literature dealing with the internal dimension of brand equity on NPOs, three in-depth interviews

were conducted with specialists from the third sector. Decisions were made about potential interviewees that could make solid contributions to the development of a robust VBBE model. Hence, we selected three experts with three different profiles (Table 1) – one academic-practitioner, one academic-researcher, and one practitioner-volunteer, hoping to gather rich qualitative data provided by their insights, experience, expertise and thoughts.

Expert 1 is an academic-practitioner, that is to say, is simultaneously a professor of social economy and social intervention and also co-founder of a NFPO dealing with social entrepreneurship projects. Expert 2 is an academic and a researcher in the areas of Sustainable Development and Social Entrepreneurship particularly examining solutions to foster sustainable development through collaboration between NGOs and NFPOs. Finally, expert 3 is a business consultant, an active volunteer for more than 10 years and also, in the last 3 years, coordinator of a Portuguese NGO with more than 400 volunteers working in five different settings (social exclusion, children with disabilities, support to isolated seniors, homeless and institutionalized children).

Interviews turn out to be indispensable and vital to discuss the adoption of EBE models to the context of formal volunteering and advancing toward a first Volunteer Brand Equity model. Issues related to the adequacy of the language, the key grounds of EBE models and the usefulness of such models in NPOs contexts were critically and deeply debated. During the interview, experts were asked to critically discuss and evaluate the appropriateness of each one of the three categories and 13 dimensions of the EBE model. Audio recording of interviews was authorized and fully transcribed. Experts were selected based on their practical and academic expertise on the subject.

Relevant insights emerged from the interviews, and afterward used to assist and support the survey design and application. Table 2 provides examples of changes introduced to the survey to encompass interviewees' suggestions, namely, formal changes but also content changes, derived from the specificity of voluntary work. For instance, in dimension *Volunteer intention to stay* we have considered 2 years, as the average time to remain in the organization, considered by the experts as a more coherent timeframe than the 5-year period suggest in the EBBE original model.

Table 1. Expert characterization.

Expert 1	PhD in Sociology, Professor and Social Economy researcher, and evaluator of projects of social and organizational intervention. Co-founder of Association for Social Entrepreneurship and Sustainability of the Third Sector
Expert 2	PhD in Sociology, Professor of Cooperation for Sustainable Development and active promoter and implementer of projects within NPO for Cooperation for Sustainable Development and Social entrepreneurship
Expert 3	Business consultant, volunteer, Coordinator in a formal volunteering organization, managing more than 400 volunteers

Table 2. Type of changes to EBE survey proposed by experts.

Type of changes	Examples	Justification
Discourse	"how and why we should do things" becomes "reason and purpose of action"	Language most suited to the context of volunteering, where the purpose of the action is fundamental
	"Job training" becomes "training for personal and professional development"	
	"Goals" becomes "values"	The human and personal dimension is more relevant in this context than the job training
	"Treats me as a human being" passes to "treats me correctly, with respect"	There is a very strong relationship between the volunteers and the values of the organization
	"Mission of the organization" becomes "brand promise"	Taking into account the human dimension inherent in voluntary activities, it was considered that this language was redundant.
Main concepts	"In the next 5 years" becomes "in the next 2 years"	In the context of this model, brand promise already encompasses the Goals, Mission, Values and Purpose of a nonprofit organization
	"Employee" becomes "Volunteer"	Time scale more coherent with the reality of this sector
	"Management" becomes Coordination/Management Team	Change because of the application context
	"Job" becomes "Volunteer work"	Different types of NPO may have different management structures
	"Client" becomes "Public"	Change because of the application context

Quantitative research design: survey, sampling, and analysis

A self-administrated questionnaire was put forward, using the contributions of the experts during the interviews and the scales adapted from the original EBBE models. A non-probabilistic and purposive sampling was used to guarantee a direct possibility of accessing a group of individuals from the target audience (Anderson, Sweeney, & Williams, 2007), that is to say, formal volunteers. Therefore, the study population comprised volunteers who formally carry out their activities within an institution or organization in the North of Portugal, representing a dimension of 535 918 individuals (National Statistics Institute [INE], 2012). A pretest was carried out and some changes were made to provide better understanding of the questions. The survey was disseminated through an online platform and data analysis was performed using SPSS.

The first part of the survey aimed at characterizing some dimensions of the volunteer work, namely the organization they volunteer for (a basic condition for being a formal volunteer), the seniority of the volunteer, the average time spent in volunteering activities per month, the role of the volunteer in the organization (coordinator or not). The second part dedicated specifically to the scales of the VBE model was organized around the 13 dimensions of the VBE model: generation of information, knowledge dissemination, volunteer attitude, organizational socialization, volunteer involvement, management support, the H factor, role clarity, brand commitment, brand citizenship behavior, volunteer satisfaction, volunteer intention to stay and positive volunteer word of mouth. A 7-point Likert scale was used (1 – totally disagree; 2 – disagree; 3 – partially disagree; 4 – indifferent; 5 – partially agree; 6 – agree; 7 – totally agree) as proposed by King and Grace (2010) and King et al. (2012) to address each dimension giving rise to a total of 66 statements.

Results and discussion

This section summarizes results in two domains, according to our research goals and theoretical framework. Firstly, findings from the interviews are presented and main changes and adaptations proposed by interviewees are highlighted. Secondly, data collected from the survey are presented through descriptive analysis, exploratory factor analysis, and correlation analysis.

Qualitative findings

After a thorough and critical debate around all the dimensions of the EBBE original models, the panel of experts suggested some changes and language adaptations to encompass the idiosyncrasies of the volunteering empirical

context (Table 2). Despite these changes, all three categories and 13 dimensions were accepted and validated as useful and necessary to understand the context of NPOs' brand equity. Proposed adaptations were mainly related to the language used to address each dimension and the key concepts supporting the model. From the 83 original statements proposed by King and Grace (2010), 17 questions were eliminated according to the experts' opinions that those were not relevant or applicable to formal volunteering institutions. This is due to the nature of volunteering work. For example, volunteers, in general, do not have a prior preparation to fulfill certain functions as occurs in business context. Hence, experts considered that it could be dangerous to rely too much on the opinion of volunteers who may not yet be prepared or knowledgeable about the organization's brand promise and may not come up with strategically productive suggestions. Additionally, the following changes were proposed and justified by the experts to enhance the VBE model (Table 2).

Regarding the dimensions of VBE model we highlight some of the main contributions derived from experts 1, 2 and 3 (henceforth E1, E2, E3):

- (1) Concerning the first dimension "generation of information" suggestions were made about references to the "coordination team" instead of "organization". Instead of an abstract concept of "organization", E1 and E3 suggested to identify the "coordination team" to whom volunteers report and with whom a direct relationship is. According to E1 *"This model [EBBE] assumes the organization as reified, autonomous, with a life of its own. But the information conveyed by volunteers is directed to their leader/coordinator; and if the information is somehow impacting but does not reach team leaders or coordinators, it has practically no value"*.
- (2) Experts draw attention to the fact that willingness to give time does not imply being prepared to convey a clear and positive opinion about the organization: *"An organization that relies heavily on volunteer information will drift a bit. Volunteers express 'everything under the sun' and there needs to be some basic coherence in identity"*(E3).
- (3) Experts considered the dimension "knowledge dissemination" as essential for the process of volunteer management and NPO brand recognition: *"There has to be a top-down coordination, because people have good will, but it's hard to know whether it is a genuine will, or a fashion. There is great disorientation in volunteers"*.(E3).
- (4) The dimension "The H factor" was considered especially relevant when cross-referenced with the information on organizational structure since it is necessary to understand if there is direct contact between volunteers and coordinators or not, in order to better evaluate the impact of the "H" factor in these organizations.

- (5) Regarding the dimension “brand commitment”, it was mentioned that this feeling is utterly important in volunteering institutions. Not all volunteers feel committed and part of the organization and “*Being a volunteer represents becoming part of the organization*” (E2).
- (6) “Brand citizenship behavior” was referred as a key dimension in the context of NPOs. “*This dimension is not so important in the business context where there is a more anonymous perspective of the employee. In a social organization, the work of the organization is soon put into check when a volunteer performs badly.*” (E3). Additionally, E3 underlines the public scrutiny that NPOs normally suffer and reinforces that: “*Being brand ambassadors means that you have taken ownership of the brand and that you have a critical awareness of it. If there is no such appropriation there will be no rooting, that is, there will be no identification and personalization ... is something that is built and must be preserved, more importantly in the current context of social organizations, with the problems that have been observed, it requires a great discipline and total transparency.*” (E3)

Quantitative findings

Sample characterization

As stated in the methodology section, only formal volunteers were subject to inquiry (227 valid responses from 28 different NPOs). Regarding the average number of hours dedicated to volunteering activities, 70% of the respondents dedicate more than 5 h a month and the remaining 30% devote less than 5 h a month (Table 3). The majority of volunteers collaborated with the organization for more than a year and a half (52.9%) and most of them do not hold coordination/direction roles (55%).

Exploratory factor analysis

An Exploratory Factor Analysis (EFA) was performed, in order to statistically validate the dimensions of the future VBE model in the Portuguese context and to group the different variables into factors corresponding to the

Table 3. Characterization of the volunteer.

		%
Average number of monthly volunteer hours	Less than 5 h/month	30
	More than 5 h/month	70
Seniority in organization	≤1 year and half	47.1
	>1 year and a half	52.9
Coordination Functions	Yes	44.9
	No	55.1

dimensions of the model. In this sense, the Kaiser-Meyer-Olkin test (KMO) was initially applied. All the dimensions have a quality of adequacy to the factor analysis. Bartlett Sphericity test allowed to conclude that there was a significant correlation between the different variables of each dimension. Likewise, the results of Cronbach Alpha test indicate an adequate internal consistency (Table A1 in Appendix).

Results of EFA are shown in the following table (Table 4).

No value of commonalities is less than 0.5 and no value of variance reaches the minimum of 60%. It should be noted that the dimensions shown in the table have already suffered the elimination of variables that presented values of commonalities less than 0.5. This was the case of the variable “D11 BNF | Volunteer satisfaction 11.1 – *I feel reasonably satisfied with my experience of volunteering* and the D12 BNF | Intent of permanence 12.3 – *If tomorrow I had the chance to go to another organization, I would refuse*. There were no significant changes to the model (besides the elimination of two variables) and the 13 dimensions of VBBB were maintained.

Descriptive statistical analysis

This section provides a general characterization of each of the 13 dimensions within each of the three main categories of the research model.

Internal brand management

The category “internal brand management” was analyzed according to the seven dimensions (Table 5) proposed by King and Grace (2009, 2010).

Considering an analysis of each of the statements, we highlight the following findings. The statement “*I like to do the volunteer work I do*”, an integral part of the “volunteer attitude toward work” dimension with a value of 6.59, is the one with the highest agreement. As a response to the way the employee feels is treated, this dimension has a considerable impact on the communication process (between the organization and the employee) as it affects their overall satisfaction with their work (Naude et al., 2003).

“*I feel that the organizational coordination team treats me correctly, with respect*,” with the score of 6.56 (very close to the previous variable) characterizes the way volunteers feel they are treated by organizations. This variable belongs to the dimension “the H Factor”. Note the absence of the variables of the dimension “information generation” in this set of eleven highest scores. The group with lower scores contains only variables of the dimension “volunteer involvement”. As suggested in the literature, employee involvement plays an important role in reinforcing organizational commitment (King & Grace, 2010), and is manifested in feedback initiatives, discussion of organizational issues, or decision support (Conduit & Mavondo, 2001). In addition, it is important to note that, regarding

Table 4. Communalities and variance explained.

Communalities		Extraction	Variance
D1 GMI Information Generation 1.1		0,767	73,715%
D1 GMI Information Generation 1.2		0,679	
D1 GMI Information Generation 1.3		0,787	
D1 GMI Information Generation 1.4		0,716	
D2 GMI Knowledge Dissemination 2.1		0,732	76,345%
D2 GMI Knowledge Dissemination 2.2		0,788	
D2 GMI Knowledge Dissemination 2.3		0,746	
D2 GMI Knowledge Dissemination 2.4		0,788	
D3 GMI Volunteer Involvement 3.1		0,747	69,294%
D3 GMI Volunteer Involvement 3.2		0,799	
D3 GMI Volunteer Involvement 3.3		0,720	
D3 GMI Volunteer Involvement 3.4		0,682	
D3 GMI Volunteer Involvement 3.5		0,703	78,720%
D3 GMI Volunteer Involvement 3.6		0,506	
D4 GMI Volunteer Attitude toward work 4.1		0,798	
D4 GMI Volunteer Attitude toward work 4.2		0,803	
D4 GMI Volunteer Attitude toward work 4.3		0,724	68,118%
D4 GMI Volunteer Attitude toward work 4.4		0,824	
D5 GMI Organizational socialization 5.1		0,610	
D5 GMI Organizational socialization 5.2		0,658	
D5 GMI Organizational socialization 5.3		0,608	74,398%
D5 GMI Organizational socialization 5.4		0,765	
D5 GMI Organizational socialization 5.5		0,764	
D6 GMI Management Support 6.1		0,814	
D6 GMI Management Support 6.2		0,687	73,414%
D6 GMI Management Support 6.3		0,670	
D6 GMI Management Support 6.4		0,737	
D6 GMI Management Support 6.5		0,869	71,717%
D6 GMI Management Support 6.6		0,671	
D6 GMI Management Support 6.7		0,761	
D7 GMI The "H" Factor 7.1		0,717	
D7 GMI The "H" Factor 7.2		0,622	78,267%
D7 GMI The "H" Factor 7.3		0,673	
D7 GMI The "H" Factor 7.4		0,785	
D7 GMI The "H" Factor 7.5		0,791	64,334%
D7 GMI The "H" Factor 7.6		0,778	
D7 GMI The "H" Factor 7.7		0,784	
D7 GMI The "H" Factor 7.8		0,787	
D7 GMI The "H" Factor 7.9		0,671	78,267%
D8 ECM Role Clarity 8.1		0,703	
D8 ECM Role Clarity 8.2		0,752	
D8 ECM Role Clarity 8.3		0,665	
D8 ECM Role Clarity 8.4		0,766	78,267%
D8 ECM Role Clarity 8.5		0,706	
D8 ECM Role Clarity 8.6		0,710	
D9 ECM Brand Commitment 9.1		0,811	
D9 ECM Brand Commitment 9.2		0,802	64,334%
D9 ECM Brand Commitment 9.3		0,756	
D9 ECM Brand Commitment 9.4		0,762	
D10 BNF Brand Citizenship Behavior 10.1		0,658	64,334%
D10 BNF Brand Citizenship Behavior 10.2		0,702	
D10 BNF Brand Citizenship Behavior 10.3		0,598	
D10 BNF Brand Citizenship Behavior 10.4		0,567	
D10 BNF Brand Citizenship Behavior 10.5		0,692	

(Continued)

Table 4. (Continued).

Communalities		Extraction	Variance
D11 BNF Volunteer Satisfaction 11.2		0,841	75,295%
D11 BNF Volunteer Satisfaction 11.3		0,864	
D11 BNF Volunteer Satisfaction 11.4		0,554	
D12 BNF Volunteer Intention to stay 12.1		0,771	81,034%
D12 BNF Volunteer Intention to stay 12.2		0,821	
D12 BNF Volunteer Intention to stay 12.4		0,839	
D13 BNF Positive Volunteer Word of Mouth 13.1		0,728	72,344%
D13 BNF Positive Volunteer Word of Mouth 13.2		0,806	
D13 BNF Positive Volunteer Word of Mouth 13.3		0,649	
D13 BNF Positive Volunteer Word of Mouth 13.4		0,710	

“internal brand management”, volunteers only “partially agree” that have “*the opportunity to comment on the initiatives before they are presented to the public*” (5,17) and “*The opportunity to discuss structural issues with coordination team*” (5,11). There are also some variables relevant to this study, because of their lower score, which should be mentioned: “*Overall, I consider that there is excellent communication within the organization*” (H Factor), with 5.58; “*In the organization, the coordination team meets with the volunteers to find out what expectations they have about their activities and functions*” (“information generation”), with 5.71. Hence, regarding the category Internal Brand Management, findings reveal that volunteers show a very positive opinion about it (Table 6).

About the dimension “Volunteer attitude toward work”, volunteers respond positively to the way they are treated in their organizations, manifesting a pleasant relationship with the work they perform (6,27). According to Naude et al. (2003), this dimension has a relevant role in the communication process, since knowledge transfer is dependent on the employees’ predisposition to receive this information, which is related to the volunteer attitude toward their work (King & Grace, 2010). Thus, in the context of the EBE model, this dimension influences the organization’s internal brand management process and consequently its brand equity (King & Grace, 2009). With respect to the “Knowledge dissemination” dimension, volunteers agree that they receive information about their role and brand promise in a clear way, enabling them to perform their tasks efficiently (6,19). This dimension, according to King and Grace (2009), is central to Internal Brand Management which depends on the organization’s ability to identify employees’ opinion’ and convey brand knowledge in the most appropriate way. In relation to the dimension “Management support” volunteers express that there is an inviting and safe working environment (6,11) and regarding “The H factor” they feel valued and respected in their organizations (6,12). The promotion of a positive environment, which encourages communication, respect, and collaboration among others, is essential for Internal Brand

Table 5. Dimensions of internal brand management (Mean and standard deviation).

1. Information Generation	M	SD
In the organization I volunteer for, the coordination team uses data gathered from volunteers to develop strategy for the organization	5.92	1.247
In the organization I volunteer for, coordination team meet with volunteers to find out what expectations they have of their work for the future.	5.71	1.409
In the organization I volunteer for, coordination team interacts directly with volunteers to find out how to make them more satisfied	5.71	1.301
The organization I volunteer for gathers information from volunteer feedback	5.92	1.335
2. Knowledge Dissemination	M	SD
In the organization I volunteer for, coordination team communicates its brand promise well to its volunteers.	5.99	1.109
In the organization I volunteer for, coordination team teaches us why we should do things and not just how we should do things.	6.33	0.942
In the organization I volunteer for, coordination team communicates the importance of my role in delivering the brand promise.	6.30	0.892
The information provided to me when I was volunteering helped me to understand my role in the context of what the organization is trying to achieve.	6.15	1.062
3. Volunteer Involvement	M	SD
I have the opportunity to comment on initiatives before they are shown to the general public.	5.17	1.758
I have the opportunity to participate in the development of new initiatives to the public (e.g.: developing innovative ideas; events)	5.54	1.488
I have the opportunity to be involved in a range of organizational initiatives (e.g.: new projects)	5.74	1.461
I have the opportunity to provide feedback about organizational initiatives (e.g.: training sessions ...)	6.00	1.302
I have the opportunity to discuss structural issues in the workplace with the coordinators	5.11	1.734
Volunteer contribution is welcomed in the organization I volunteer for.	6.38	1.008
4. Volunteer Attitude toward their work	M	SD
I consider that my work as volunteer is interesting and stimulating on the whole.	6.38	0.911
I enjoy doing the volunteer work that I do	6.59	0.783
This is my ideal volunteer work	5.79	1.286
I feel very positive toward my volunteer work.	6.30	0.973
5. Organizational Socialization	M	SD
The organization I volunteer for has provided excellent personal and professional training for me.	5.93	1.215
The training in the organization I volunteer for has enabled me to do my work well.	5.78	1.304
The goals of the organization I volunteer for are very clear	6.36	0.983
The instructions given by my coordinators have been valuable in helping me to do better work	5.90	1.234
My work environment helps me to understand how I should behave in my job.	6.11	1.080
6. Management Support	M	SD
The organization I volunteer for values my contribution to its well-being.	6.19	1.091
In the organization I volunteer for, the Coordination team strongly considers my goals and values	5.99	1.181
In the organization I volunteer, help is available from the coordination team when I have a problem.	6.23	1.093
In the organization I volunteer for, the Coordination team tries to make my work as interesting as possible.	5.90	1.217
In the organization I volunteer for, the Coordination team is willing to extend themselves in order to help me to perform my work to the best of my ability.	6.11	1.124
In the organization I volunteer for, the coordination team understands my problems and needs.	5.95	1.247

(Continued)

Table 5. (Continued).

In the organization I volunteer for, the coordination team acknowledges the efforts of employees	6.36	1.026
7. The “H” factor	M	SD
I feel that a good deal of cooperation exists between coordination team and the volunteers of the organization I volunteer for.	6.07	1.150
Overall, I would suggest excellent communication exists within the organization I volunteer for.	5.58	1.355
The organization I volunteer for has a clear set of goals and values which everyone is pursuing together to achieve.	5.89	1.264
I feel that I am a respected and valued member of the organization I volunteer for	6.22	1.120
I feel that I can trust the coordination team of the organization I volunteer for.	6.31	1.090
I feel that the coordination team of the organization I volunteer for trusts me to do a good job	6.35	0.968
I feel that the organization I volunteer for is considerate (to the best of their ability) of the impact their decisions have on me	6.04	1.151
I feel that the organization I volunteer for is considerate (to the best of their ability) of the impact their decisions have on my role.	6.06	1.162
I feel like the organization I volunteer for treats me like a human being (e.g. with respect, is cooperative ...)	6.56	0.882

Table 6. Dimensions of internal brand management. Total.

Category	Dimension	M	M
Internal brand management	Information Generation	5.82	6.04
	Knowledge Dissemination	6.19	
	Volunteer Involvement	5.65	
	Volunteer Attitude toward their work	6.27	
	Organizational Socialization	6.02	
	Management Support	6.11	
	The “H” Factor	6.12	

Management (King & Grace, 2009). The dimension “Organizational socialization” reveals that volunteers are well aware of the set of values and guidance conveyed by their organization’s coordination and acknowledge their availability to help them performing their role better (6,02). According to Kelley, Skinner and Donnelly (1992), this dimension causes an increase in motivation, effort, and employee organizational commitment, thus influencing, once again, internal brand management (King & Grace, 2010). In a less positive way, volunteers affirm that their organizations invest moderately in the collection of feedback and in creation of moments of direct interaction between themselves and the coordination of the organization (“Information Generation”: 5,82). This feedback exercise allows a collection of information essential to the internal communication process and consequent interaction between organization and employees, being vital for the good functioning of the organization (Naude et al., 2003) and for the success of management strategies of the internal brand (King & Grace, 2009). Furthermore, volunteers consider that their active participation in the

discussion and development of the organization's initiatives is moderately taken into account ("Volunteer Involvement": 5.65).

In short, the general characterization of Internal Brand Management in the context of nonprofit organizations is quite positive, showing that these organizations have performed positively in this regard, albeit with room for improvement.

Volunteer brand knowledge effects

Findings reveal that all variables of the dimension "Brand Commitment" have the highest scores, clearly evidencing the importance of this dimension in the context of the category "Effects of brand knowledge" (Table 7). Those with greater values (equal to 6.50 or more), thus placing themselves closer to the "total agreement" are: *"I am proud to be part of the organization I volunteer for"* (6,62), and *"I am willing to put in extra effort beyond what is expected to make the organization I volunteer for successful."* (6,50).

Volunteers expressed a relationship of complicity with the organization, feeling valued in their work and committed to the brand promise (Table 8). This dimension, represented by the volunteer's sense of belonging in relation to the brand, is an important effect of brand knowledge, as it ensures that volunteers express a genuine desire and motivation to disseminate knowledge and brand promise to the outside (King & Grace, 2010). According to Jones et al. (2003), when the relevant knowledge to the success of the function is transmitted to the employee, there is an increase in the

Table 7. Dimensions of volunteer brand knowledge effects (Mean and standard deviation).

Role clarity	M	SD
I know how I am expected to handle unusual problems and situations while on the volunteer work.	5.67	1.168
I know exactly what outputs is expected of me on the volunteer work	5.89	1.106
Information about my organization's brand improved my basic understanding of my work as a volunteer	5.93	1.076
I understand what is expected of me	6.10	1.015
I know how to make specific decisions for my volunteer work	5.88	1.051
I know how to deliver the brand promise for the organization where I volunteer	6.11	0.996
Brand commitment	M	SD
I am proud to be part of the organization I volunteer for	6.62	0.851
My values are similar to those of the organization I volunteer for	6.44	0.964
I am willing to put in extra effort beyond what is expected to make the organization I volunteer for successful.	6.50	0.849
I feel like I really fit in where I work	6.22	1.031

Table 8. Dimensions of volunteer brand knowledge effects (Total).

Category	Dimension	M	M
Volunteer brand knowledge effects	Role clarity	5.93	6.185
	Brand commitment	6.44	

level of commitment toward the organization. Some effects stand out such as the volunteers sense of pride to be part of the organization (6, 62), or an obvious willingness to go beyond what their basic functions are (*I'm willing to make an extra effort, beyond what is expected, to make the organization succeed* – 6.50). Regarding the dimension “Role clarity”, volunteers show moderate understanding about their roles and goals within the organization, as a result of the organization’s communication of brand knowledge (King & Grace, 2010). However, volunteers have some doubts about the decision-making process and reaction to less common situations (*I know how to make specific decisions for my volunteer work* – 5.88; and *I know how you expect me to deal with situations and problems during voluntary work* – 5,67).

VBE benefits

In relation to the four dimensions of the EBE benefits (Tables 9 and 10), findings indicate that the one with the highest values of agreement is the “Positive volunteer word of mouth” (6.62). Regarding the dimension “Brand citizenship behavior” (6.25) volunteers reveal more positive answers regarding “*pass on their knowledge about the organization to new volunteers*” (6.44).

Table 9. Dimensions of VBE benefits (Mean and standard deviation).

Brand Citizenship Behavior	M	SD
I demonstrate behaviors that are consistent with the brand promise of the organization where I volunteer	6.30	0.917
I consider the impact in my organization's brand before communicating or taking action in any situation	6.17	1.076
I show extra initiative to ensure that my behavior remains consistent with the brand promise of the organization where I volunteer.	6.00	1.115
If given the opportunity, I pass on my knowledge about my organization's brand to new volunteers	6.44	0.820
I am always interested to learn about my organization's brand and what it means for me in my role	6.35	0.931
Volunteer Satisfaction	M	SD
I feel a great sense of satisfaction from my I work as a volunteer	6.35	0.982
I am satisfied with my overall volunteer work	6.44	0.897
I would not consider leaving my current work as a volunteer should another volunteering opportunity be presented to me	5.82	1.457
Volunteer Intention to stay	M	SD
I plan to be with the organization where I volunteer for a while	6.07	1.469
I plan to be with the organization where I volunteer for two years from now	5.45	1.812
I plan to stay with the organization where I volunteer next year	6.04	1.583
Positive volunteer word of mouth	M	SD
I say positive things about the organization where I do volunteer work.	6.66	0.720
I would recommended the organization to other volunteers	6.72	0.729
I enjoy talking about the organization I work as a volunteer	6.45	1.122
I talk positively about the organization I work as a volunteer to others	6.67	0.673

Table 10. Dimensions of VBE benefits (Total).

Category	Dimension	M	M
VBE benefits	Brand citizenship behavior	6.25	6.23
	Volunteer Satisfaction	6.2	
	Volunteer Intention to stay	5.85	
	Positive Volunteer World of mouth	6.62	

Table 11. Correlation tests.

		Brand Citizenship Behavior	Intention to stay	Positive volunteer word of mouth	Volunteer satisfaction
Role clarity	Pearson	,717**	,509**	,590**	,613**
	Correlation				
	Sig. (2-tailed)	,000	,000	,000	,000
	N	227	227	227	227
Brand commitment	Pearson	,714**	,506**	,772**	,713**
	Correlation				
	Sig. (2-tailed)	,000	,000	,000	,000
	N	227	227	227	227
	Sig. (2-tailed)	,000	,000	,000	
	N	227	227	227	227

In the dimension “Volunteer satisfaction” (6.2) it is considered that volunteers are *satisfied with their overall volunteer work* (6.44). Concerning “Volunteer intention to stay” (5.85), respondents revealed a higher level of agreement with the statement “*I plan to be with the organization where I volunteer for a while*” (6.07), and when asked about their intention to stay in the long run (2 years from now), despite positive findings reveal slightly lower concordance levels (5.45). Finally, with respect to the “Positive volunteer word of mouth” dimension, which showed a mean of agreement higher than the other dimensions (6.62), respondents stated they *would recommend the organization to other volunteers* (6.72) and *talk positively about the organization they work as a volunteer to others* (6.67).

Correlations were made to understand the relationship between the variables within “volunteer brand knowledge effects” (“role clarity” and “brand commitment”) and the remaining VBE Benefits: “brand citizenship behavior”, “volunteer satisfaction”, “intention to stay” and “positive volunteer word of mouth” (Table 11). Both “role clarity” and “brand commitment” are positively correlated with the remaining variables. The dimension “brand commitment” has higher Pearson coefficient. Thus, it should be noted that “brand commitment”, “positive volunteer word of mouth” and “brand citizenship behavior” were strongly positively correlated [$r(227) = .772, p = .000$ and $r(227) = .714, p = .000$, respectively]. To such a degree, it can be concluded that volunteers who are more committed to their NPO brands will disseminate a more “positive volunteer word of mouth”, have higher

levels of satisfaction, reveal greater intention to stay in the NPO in the long term and further develop their “brand citizenship behavior”, than those who find themselves less committed to the brand.

Similar to King and Grace (2010) findings, volunteers who show deep understanding on how to deliver the brand promise (“role clarity”) and feel committed with the NPO brand derive organizational benefits (VBE benefits).

Likewise, there is a positive correlation between all dimensions of “internal brand management” and dimensions of “volunteer brand knowledge effects” (“role clarity” and “brand commitment”, Table 12). Regarding “role clarity” there is a stronger correlation with the dimensions “the H factor” [$r(227) = .701, p = .000$], “management support” [$r(227) = .675, p = .000$] and “organizational socialization” [$r(227) = .647, p = .000$]. In relation to the “brand commitment” dimension, the highest levels of correlation occur with the same dimensions: “the H factor” [$r(227) = .765, p = .000$], “organizational socialization” [$r(227) = .751, p = .000$], “management support” [$r(227) = .738, p = .000$] and also with “volunteer attitude toward work” [$r(227) = .695, p = .000$].

Thus, in addition to the relationship previously studied (King & Grace, 2010) between ‘knowledge dissemination’ and ‘information generation’ with ‘volunteer brand knowledge effects’ (‘role clarity’ and ‘brand commitment’), this study demonstrates a positive relationship between the remaining dimensions of Internal Brand Management. So, when a more positive Internal Brand Management is perceived, a better role clarity as well as stronger brand commitment is observed. The dimension in which this relationship is most positive is ‘the H factor’ in the ‘organization socialization’ and also in the ‘management support’.

A multiple linear regression was run to predict VBBE benefits variables (volunteer satisfaction, positive volunteer word-of-mouth, intention to stay and brand citizenship Behavior) based on two independent variables: role clarity and brand commitment. The independent variables have a predictive ability of all VBBE benefits variables, except on the variable positive word-of-mouth, in which only brand commitment has statistical significance. Therefore, the independent variables role clarity and brand commitment are able to explain: a) 59.7% of the variable positive volunteer word-of-mouth [$F(2,224) = 165,782, p < .000$] where only brand commitment was a significant predictor ($p < .005$); b) 58.8% of the variable brand citizenship behavior [$F(2,224) = 159,585, p < .000$] where both were significant predictors; c) 52.4% of the variable volunteer satisfaction [$F(2,224) = 123,167, p < .005$] where both were significant predictors; and finally d) only 29.6% of the variable intention to stay [$F(2,224) = 47,008, p < .005$].

Table 12. Correlation tests.

		Information generation	Management Support	Volunteer attitude	Volunteer involvement	Knowledge dissemination	H Factor	Organizational socialization
Role clarity	Pearson	,387**	,675**	,585**	,464**	,633**	,701**	,647**
	Correlation							
	Sig. (2-tailed)	,000	,000	,000	,000	,000	,000	,000
Brand commitment	N	227	227	227	227	227	227	227
	Pearson	,416**	,738**	,695**	,471**	,590**	,765**	,751**
	Correlation							
	Sig. (2-tailed)	,000	,000	,000	,000	,000	,000	,000
	N	227	227	227	227	227	227	227

Conclusions, implications, and avenues for future research

This exploratory study examined the adequacy of adopting EBBE dimensions to the context of formal voluntary work in NPOs, contributing to the under-researched area of building brand equity from volunteers' relationships with their NPO.

First, by advancing with a proposal for a Volunteer Brand Equity (VBE) model, this article contributes to the currently limited literature on the importance of internal marketing strategies to attract, engage and retain volunteers. This study is the first step in developing a new model for internal brand management in NPOs, focused on the role and contributions of volunteers to build NPOs' brand equity. Hence, the validation of the VBE model applied to formal volunteering contexts allows us to put forward a theoretical contribution to an organizational context that to date has received little or almost no attention from the scientific community. Additionally, the study provided development of a set of scales that will allow the application of the VBE model to other volunteering scenarios, allowing the scientific community to investigate internal brand management elements, the effects of brand knowledge on volunteers and the benefits of VBE. The application of VBE model to the Portuguese NPO context highlighted the importance of volunteer brand knowledge effects on the overall NPO brand equity. Our findings reinforced the key role-played by role clarity and brand commitment in engaging volunteers with their NPO brand, which affects their overall satisfaction and motivation to stay in the organization.

Second, regarding the implications of this study for practitioners in NPO contexts, it is our understanding that the VBE model represents a practical tool for analyzing internal brand management strategies, evaluating the effects of brand knowledge on volunteers, and realizing the benefits of VBE for volunteers and consequently for the NPO brand. In fact, according to Shah, Rust, Parasuraman, Staelin, and Day (2006), it is this ability to measure internal results that enhance organizational performance.

Given the importance of brand management for the very development of organizations (Kylander & Stone, 2012), these results assume considerable practical relevance. In a holistic way, our findings may be used by practitioners to achieve better results in attracting, engaging and retaining volunteers by: i) improving the volunteer experience to the extent that organizations will have more information on how to interact with them, in order to enhance their overall satisfaction; ii) building up closer relationships with the volunteers by generating and disseminating knowledge about the NPO brand promise and thus enhancing their role, their feeling of belonging and the way they identify themselves with the brand.

In terms of limitations of the study, we acknowledge that our survey and interviews covered responses from the northern Portuguese context of NPOs.

Despite its exploratory nature, to properly develop a new VBE model, future studies will need to open up the survey to other regions and other countries. Hence, and following other CBBE (e.g. Buil et al., 2008) and EBBE (e.g. Poulis & Wisker, 2016) studies which collected and compared data from consumers in different countries, we invite researchers to apply the Volunteer Based Brand Equity model to other volunteering settings in other countries, to allow for further understanding of the phenomena and also to identify differences among volunteers from different socio-economic-cultural backgrounds.

Regarding the interviews, only three experts have been heard in this pilot study. Although having a high level of experience and a very relevant theoretical-practical knowledge, their comments on the model may have introduced failures in the system due to the reduced number of opinions. We recommend the selection of a broader and more complete panel of experts in order to further investigate the adequacy of EBE dimensions to the context of formal volunteering, using the Delphi method in a larger scale, for example. Furthermore, this paper reports findings of the first stage of the validation of VBE model. Future research should build upon the scales validated in this study to form first level constructs of internal brand management, volunteer brand knowledge effects and VBE benefits, similarly to EBE original models.

Lastly, volunteer and experts responses led us to question the influence that coordination/management function, seniority of the volunteer and the number of hours dedicated to volunteering activities, might have on the NPO brand equity. These variables may constitute potential future research themes.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the authors.

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Appendix

Table A1. KMO and Alpha Cronbach results for VBE dimensions.

Dimension	KMO	Alpha Cronbach
D1 GMI Information Generation	0,804	0.879
D2 GMI Knowledge Dissemination	0,842	0.893
D3 GMI Volunteer Attitude toward their Work	0,831	0.894
D4 GMI Organizational Socialization	0,825	0.880
D5 GMI Volunteer Involvement	0,880	0.907
D6 GMI Management Support	0,934	0.941
D7 GMI The "H" Factor	0,904	0.952
D8 ECM Role Clarity	0,904	0.920
D9 ECM Brand Commitment	0,838	0.904
D10 BNF Brand Citizenship Behavior	0,799	0.858
D11 BNF Volunteer Satisfaction	0,638	0.785
D12 BNF Volunteer Intention to stay	0,736	0.880
D13 BNF Positive Volunteer Word of Mouth	0,787	0.848